

Limitations of Anonymous Self-Reported Admissions Data

Anonymous self-reported admissions data presents several challenges when conducting quantitative analysis. Since submissions on GradCafe are voluntary and anonymous, there is no reliable way to verify whether the information provided by users is accurate.

Applicants may unintentionally enter incorrect information or choose to omit details such as GPA, GRE scores, or admission outcomes. In addition, many records contain missing values, making it difficult to calculate statistics that accurately represent the entire applicant population. The quality of the dataset is also affected by the web scraping and data cleaning process, as inconsistencies in formatting and user-generated content can introduce errors into the final database.

Another important limitation is selection bias. Individuals who receive admission offers may be more likely to share their results online than applicants who are rejected or choose not to report their outcomes. As a result, acceptance rates, GPA averages, and other metrics derived from GradCafe data may differ substantially from official university statistics. During this project, some records also required standardization using automated cleaning and LLM-assisted techniques, which may not always perfectly identify universities or programs. Therefore, the findings generated from this analysis should be interpreted as insights from a self-selected sample rather than definitive measures of graduate admissions outcomes.